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Why do things go wrong?

Public policy failures are born of: (1) The information constraint; (2) The knowledge constraint; (3) The resource constraint; (4) The administrative constraint; and (5) The voter rationality constraint. These five problems interact, and jointly generate government failure, of both kinds: pursuing the wrong objectives and failing on the objectives that have been established.

Element 1: The information constraint

Why do things go wrong? Because we are flying blind.

India is in poor shape in terms of the range of information available to policymakers, the errors in data, and the delays in data. Policymakers just do not know what is going on.

The criminal justice system in Delhi should evolve based on a quarterly 'Crime Victimization Survey', which measures the outcomes of the criminal justice system based on asking a random sample of persons. This information infrastructure is lacking in India. Under these conditions, episodes like a horrific rape event impinge upon the policy process and dominate perceptions.

In the modern age of electronic and social media, these outliers gain visibility and become clickbait. Practitioners tend to be well informed about outliers, and outliers exert a disproportionate influence upon forming a view of the world. This is a poor way to proceed. Systematic measurement, and